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Risk Register

A Standing Log for Naming, Owning, and Resolving Account Risk

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Risk Register

Identifying, Managing, and Preventing Customer Risks Before They Escalate

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Introduction

"Customer churn is rarely a surprise. More often, it's the result of risks that were identified too late---or identified but never acted upon."

Every customer relationship carries risk.

Some risks are technical.

Others are operational, commercial, organizational, or strategic.

The difference between a healthy customer portfolio and one with unpredictable churn often comes down to one question:

How early did we recognize the risk?

Many Customer Success teams document risks only after a customer escalates an issue or expresses dissatisfaction.

By that point, the problem has already begun affecting trust, adoption, or business outcomes.

Effective Customer Success operates differently.

It identifies risks early, documents them consistently, assigns ownership, monitors progress, and takes action before those risks develop into customer crises.

This is the purpose of a Customer Risk Register.

A Risk Register is a centralized record of every active customer risk, its probability, potential business impact, ownership, mitigation plan, and current status.

Rather than relying on memory or scattered meeting notes, every Customer Success Manager follows the same structured process for identifying and managing customer risk.

The objective is not to eliminate every risk.

That is impossible.

The objective is to ensure that no significant risk goes unnoticed, unmanaged, or unaddressed.

The strongest Customer Success organizations understand that every unresolved risk has the potential to affect adoption, business outcomes, customer confidence, renewal, and long-term partnership growth.

Managing risk proactively is therefore one of the most valuable responsibilities of a Customer Success Manager.

A Risk Register does not exist to document failure.

It exists to prevent it.

Chapter 1

Why Risk Management Matters in Customer Success

Customer Success is often associated with adoption, customer satisfaction, renewals, and growth.

However, behind each of these outcomes lies another responsibility that is equally important:

Risk Management.

Every customer account contains uncertainty.

A project may experience delays.

A key stakeholder may resign.

Business priorities may change.

Executive sponsorship may disappear.

Budgets may be reduced.

Product adoption may decline.

Support issues may increase.

Individually, these events may appear manageable.

Combined, they can significantly increase the likelihood of customer dissatisfaction or churn.

Without a structured process for identifying and tracking these risks, Customer Success Managers often become reactive instead of proactive.

Risk Management provides visibility.

It helps teams answer critical questions before problems become severe.

What risks currently threaten customer success?

Which risks require immediate attention?

Who owns resolving each issue?

What actions are already underway?

How likely is each risk to affect renewal?

A standardized Risk Register also improves collaboration.

Customer Success, Product, Support, Professional Services, Sales, and Leadership all gain access to the same information, reducing confusion and improving accountability.

Perhaps most importantly, Risk Management protects customer trust.

Customers expect their strategic partners to identify potential challenges before they become serious problems.

Organizations that consistently recognize and address risks early build stronger relationships because customers see them as proactive advisors rather than reactive vendors.

Effective Customer Success is not measured by the number of problems solved.

It is measured by the number of problems customers never experience because they were prevented in the first place.

Chapter 2

Understanding Customer Risk

Customer Risk is any event, condition, or trend that could prevent a customer from achieving their desired business outcomes.

Risk does not necessarily mean that a customer will churn.

It simply means there is an increased probability that the customer's success could be negatively affected if no action is taken.

One of the biggest misconceptions in Customer Success is believing that risk only exists after customers complain.

In reality, risk begins much earlier.

It starts when adoption slows.

When executive engagement declines.

When implementation milestones slip.

When business priorities change.

When customer champions leave the organization.

Most risks develop gradually rather than appearing suddenly.

A well-managed Risk Register helps Customer Success Managers identify these early warning signs before they become visible to the customer.

Customer risks generally fall into several categories:

Technical Risks.

Operational Risks.

Relationship Risks.

Commercial Risks.

Strategic Risks.

Organizational Risks.

Support Risks.

Adoption Risks.

Understanding these categories allows Customer Success Managers to identify patterns rather than treating every issue as an isolated event.

Every identified risk should answer four questions:

What could happen?

Why could it happen?

What would the impact be?

What action should we take now?

Risk management is not about predicting the future.

It is about preparing for it.

Chapter 3

When Risks Should Be Logged

One of the most common mistakes Customer Success teams make is waiting until a problem becomes serious before documenting it.

By that stage, recovery often becomes significantly more difficult.

Risks should be logged the moment they are identified---not when they become emergencies.

Several moments throughout the customer lifecycle commonly introduce new risks.

During Discovery

Business objectives are unclear.

Stakeholders are missing.

Success metrics have not been agreed.

Executive sponsorship is weak.

During Onboarding

Implementation delays.

Incomplete technical requirements.

Poor stakeholder participation.

Training attendance is low.

Timeline changes.

During Adoption

Declining product usage.

Low feature adoption.

Reduced meeting attendance.

Customer engagement decreases.

During Executive Reviews

Business priorities change.

New executive leadership.

Budget uncertainty.

Expansion postponed.

Negative customer feedback.

Before Renewal

Commercial concerns.

Procurement delays.

Contract negotiations.

Competitive activity.

Reduced executive engagement.

After Significant Business Events

Company mergers.

Acquisitions.

Layoffs.

Leadership restructuring.

Regulatory changes.

Economic uncertainty.

Product incidents.

Support escalations.

A Risk Register should remain active throughout the entire customer lifecycle.

Risk management is continuous---not event-driven.

Chapter 4

The Customer Risk Management Framework

A structured Risk Management Framework ensures every Customer Success Manager evaluates risks consistently.

This framework consists of six core elements.

Element One

Risk Category

Classify every risk.

Typical categories include:

Technical.

Operational.

Commercial.

Relationship.

Adoption.

Support.

Strategic.

Financial.

Organizational.

Classification makes portfolio reporting significantly easier.

Element Two

Risk Description

Clearly explain:

What is happening?

Why is it a concern?

Avoid vague statements.

Instead of writing:

"Customer engagement is low."

Write:

"Executive sponsor has missed the last three Executive Business Reviews and product usage has declined by 18% over the past six weeks."

Specific risks create actionable conversations.

Element Three

Probability

Estimate the likelihood that the risk will occur.

Typical ratings include:

Low.

Medium.

High.

Very High.

Probability should reflect available evidence rather than assumptions.

Element Four

Business Impact

Estimate the potential consequence if the risk is not addressed.

Examples include:

Minor operational disruption.

Delayed implementation.

Reduced adoption.

Commercial delay.

Renewal risk.

Customer churn.

Revenue loss.

Element Five

Owner

Every risk requires one accountable owner.

Possible owners include:

Customer Success Manager.

Implementation Manager.

Support Manager.

Product Manager.

Executive Sponsor.

Sales Representative.

Shared ownership often leads to no ownership.

Assign one primary owner.

Element Six

Mitigation Plan

Every documented risk should include:

Immediate actions.

Long-term actions.

Target completion date.

Current status.

Expected outcome.

A Risk Register without mitigation plans is simply a list of problems.

The framework transforms problems into manageable action plans.

Chapter 5

Building a Risk Register Step-by-Step

Creating a Risk Register is a straightforward process when approached consistently.

Step One

Identify potential risks.

Gather information from:

Discovery meetings.

Implementation updates.

Customer Health Scores.

Executive Business Reviews.

Support tickets.

Customer feedback.

Product usage analytics.

Step Two

Categorize the risk.

Assign every risk to a defined category.

Consistent categorization improves portfolio reporting and trend analysis.

Step Three

Assess probability.

Determine how likely the risk is to occur based on observable evidence.

Avoid speculation.

Step Four

Assess business impact.

Estimate how severely the customer relationship would be affected if the risk materialized.

Consider:

Business objectives.

Operational disruption.

Customer satisfaction.

Commercial implications.

Renewal impact.

Step Five

Assign ownership.

Identify one individual responsible for managing the risk until closure.

Ownership creates accountability.

Step Six

Develop a mitigation plan.

Document:

Immediate actions.

Long-term strategy.

Success criteria.

Review schedule.

Target resolution date.

Step Seven

Monitor progress.

Review risks regularly.

Update status.

Close resolved risks.

Escalate unresolved risks.

A Risk Register should function as a living document that evolves alongside the customer relationship rather than a report reviewed only during renewal discussions.

Chapter 6

Types of Customer Risks

Every customer relationship is exposed to different forms of risk.

Recognizing these categories helps Customer Success Managers respond more effectively.

Technical Risk

System failures.

Integration problems.

Configuration issues.

Performance concerns.

Security vulnerabilities.

Adoption Risk

Declining user engagement.

Low feature adoption.

Incomplete workflows.

Poor administrator participation.

Relationship Risk

Champion departure.

Executive disengagement.

Poor stakeholder coverage.

Communication breakdown.

Operational Risk

Delayed implementation.

Resource shortages.

Missed milestones.

Project management issues.

Commercial Risk

Budget reductions.

Procurement delays.

Competitive pricing.

Contract disputes.

Strategic Risk

Business priorities change.

Company acquisitions.

Organizational restructuring.

Leadership changes.

Support Risk

Increasing support tickets.

Slow resolution times.

Recurring technical issues.

Customer frustration.

Compliance Risk

Regulatory changes.

Security requirements.

Audit failures.

Policy updates.

Practical Scenario

A healthcare provider successfully completed implementation and maintained strong product adoption.

However, the customer's executive sponsor accepted a position with another organization.

The replacement executive had no previous involvement in the implementation and questioned whether the platform aligned with new strategic priorities.

Although product usage remained high, Relationship Risk immediately increased.

The Customer Success Manager responded by scheduling executive alignment sessions, presenting measurable business outcomes, and rebuilding stakeholder relationships before renewal planning began.

The product had not changed.

The business value had not changed.

Only the stakeholder landscape had changed.

Recognizing this organizational risk early prevented a much larger commercial risk later.

Understanding different risk categories allows Customer Success Managers to identify hidden threats before they affect customer success.

Chapter 7

Assessing Probability & Business Impact

Not every customer risk deserves the same level of attention.

Some risks are unlikely to occur and would have little effect even if they did.

Others may have a low probability but would create severe business consequences if they materialized.

The purpose of Risk Assessment is to evaluate every identified risk using two dimensions:

Probability

How likely is this risk to occur?

Business Impact

If the risk occurs, how severely will it affect the customer relationship?

Evaluating both dimensions helps Customer Success Managers prioritize resources effectively rather than treating every issue as equally important.

Probability Scale

A simple four-level probability model provides consistency across Customer Success teams.

Low

The risk is unlikely to occur.

There is little evidence suggesting the situation will worsen.

Routine monitoring is sufficient.

Medium

Some warning signs are beginning to appear.

The situation requires observation and periodic follow-up.

Preventive actions should begin.

High

Multiple indicators suggest the risk is becoming increasingly likely.

Immediate mitigation planning should begin.

Leadership may need visibility.

Very High

The risk is either already occurring or is expected to occur within a short period unless immediate action is taken.

Executive involvement is often required.

Business Impact Scale

Business Impact measures the potential consequences if the risk becomes reality.

Low Impact

Minimal operational disruption.

Little effect on customer satisfaction.

No significant commercial implications.

Medium Impact

Temporary implementation delays.

Reduced customer efficiency.

Additional Customer Success involvement required.

High Impact

Business objectives delayed.

Executive confidence reduced.

Expansion opportunities postponed.

Renewal discussions affected.

Critical Impact

Major customer dissatisfaction.

Executive escalation required.

High likelihood of churn.

Revenue loss.

Strategic partnership damaged.

Risk Matrix

Probability Low Medium **High Impact** **Critical Impact** Impact **Impact**

Low Monitor Monitor Review Review

Medium Monitor Mitigate Mitigate Escalate

High Mitigate Mitigate Escalate Immediate Action

Very High Escalate Immediate Executive Executive Action Recovery Recovery

This matrix allows Customer Success Managers to quickly determine the urgency of each identified risk.

Practical Scenario

A customer delays administrator training by one week because of internal scheduling conflicts.

Probability of long-term impact:

Low.

Business Impact:

Low.

Recommended action:

Reschedule training and continue monitoring.

Another customer announces that its executive sponsor has resigned while product adoption has declined for three consecutive months and renewal is only ninety days away.

Probability:

Very High.

Business Impact:

Critical.

Recommended action:

Executive escalation, stakeholder mapping update, revised Success Plan, and weekly recovery meetings.

Risk assessment should always drive prioritization.

The highest risks deserve the fastest response.

Chapter 8

Risk Ownership & Accountability

One of the biggest reasons customer risks remain unresolved is simple:

Everyone assumes someone else is handling them.

A Risk Register without ownership quickly becomes a list of observations rather than a management tool.

Every identified risk must have one clearly assigned owner.

That individual becomes responsible for coordinating mitigation efforts, monitoring progress, communicating updates, and confirming when the risk has been resolved.

Ownership does not necessarily mean completing every task personally.

It means ensuring the work gets done.

Depending on the nature of the risk, ownership may belong to different functions.

Customer Success Manager

Business outcomes.

Customer communication.

Executive engagement.

Renewal readiness.

Adoption improvement.

Implementation Manager

Implementation delays.

Configuration issues.

Project planning.

Timeline management.

Product Team

Feature requests.

Product limitations.

Roadmap discussions.

Known software defects.

Support Team

Technical incidents.

Escalated support cases.

Service interruptions.

Recurring product issues.

Sales Team

Commercial negotiations.

Expansion planning.

Contract changes.

Pricing discussions.

Executive Sponsor

Cross-functional escalation.

Strategic decision making.

Resource allocation.

Executive alignment.

Although several departments may contribute toward resolving a risk, accountability should remain with one primary owner.

This eliminates confusion and ensures consistent follow-up.

Practical Scenario

A customer's implementation is delayed because of incomplete API integration.

The Customer Success Manager coordinates communication with the customer.

The Implementation Manager oversees project delivery.

The Product Team provides engineering support.

The Support Team monitors technical issues.

Despite multiple contributors, the Implementation Manager remains the accountable owner because the delay falls within implementation execution.

Clear ownership accelerates resolution.

Unclear ownership prolongs risk.

Chapter 9

Risk Mitigation Planning

Identifying a risk is only the first step.

The real value of a Risk Register comes from defining clear actions that reduce either the probability of the risk occurring or the impact if it does.

Every mitigation plan should answer five questions:

What action will we take immediately?

Who is responsible?

When will the action be completed?

How will we measure progress?

When will we review the outcome?

Mitigation strategies generally fall into four categories.

Prevent

Reduce the likelihood that the risk occurs.

Example:

Provide additional administrator training to improve adoption before usage declines.

Reduce

Minimize the business impact if the risk occurs.

Example:

Develop backup stakeholder relationships before the primary champion leaves.

Transfer

Assign responsibility to another team better equipped to resolve the issue.

Example:

Escalate product defects to Engineering while Customer Success manages customer communication.

Accept

Some risks cannot reasonably be prevented.

These should still be documented, monitored, and reviewed regularly.

Example:

Industry-wide regulatory changes affecting every customer.

Practical Scenario

Risk:

Executive sponsor has become disengaged.

Mitigation Plan:

Schedule an Executive Business Review.

Reconnect business outcomes to strategic priorities.

Identify additional executive stakeholders.

Update the Stakeholder Map.

Increase executive communication cadence.

Review progress within thirty days.

The objective is not simply to document actions.

The objective is to restore customer confidence before risk becomes reality.

Chapter 10

Escalation Framework

Not every customer risk should remain within the Customer Success team.

Some risks require additional expertise, faster decision-making, or executive involvement.

An Escalation Framework defines exactly when and how risks should be elevated.

Escalation should be based on objective criteria rather than individual judgment.

Typical escalation triggers include:

Health Score moves to Red.

Executive sponsor resigns.

Critical implementation delays.

Security incidents.

Major service outages.

High-value renewal at risk.

Customer requests executive involvement.

Commercial disputes.

Multiple unresolved support escalations.

Level 1

Customer Success Management

Customer Success Manager owns mitigation.

Routine monitoring.

Weekly review.

Level 2

Cross-Functional Support

Customer Success.

Support.

Implementation.

Product.

Sales.

Joint recovery planning.

Level 3

Leadership Escalation

Customer Success Leadership.

Product Leadership.

Support Leadership.

Executive Sponsors.

Formal recovery plan.

Executive communication.

Level 4

Executive Recovery

Chief Customer Officer.

VP Customer Success.

Executive Sponsor.

Customer Executive Leadership.

Strategic intervention.

Commercial review.

Executive recovery meetings.

Escalation should never be viewed as failure.

Escalation demonstrates that the organization is responding with the appropriate level of support before customer trust is damaged.

The best Customer Success teams escalate early.

Not late.

Chapter 11

Risk Review Cadence

A Risk Register is only valuable if it remains current.

Many organizations build comprehensive Risk Registers during onboarding or implementation, only to revisit them months later when renewal discussions begin.

By then, many risks have already evolved, new risks have emerged, and previous mitigation plans are no longer relevant.

Effective Customer Success teams establish a consistent review cadence that ensures risks remain visible throughout the customer lifecycle.

The frequency of reviews should reflect both the customer's importance and the level of risk associated with the account.

Weekly Reviews

Weekly reviews are appropriate for:

- High-risk accounts.
- Customers in active implementation.
- Accounts under executive recovery.
- Customers experiencing critical product issues.

Weekly reviews should focus on:

Current risk status.

Mitigation progress.

Newly identified risks.

Blocked action items.

Escalation requirements.

Monthly Reviews

Monthly reviews should be conducted for every managed account.

During these reviews, Customer Success Managers should:

Review all active risks.

Close resolved risks.

Update probability and business impact.

Assign new mitigation actions.

Review Customer Health Scores.

Update stakeholders.

Monthly reviews help identify gradual changes before they become serious concerns.

Quarterly Reviews

Quarterly reviews should align with Executive Business Reviews.

These sessions should evaluate:

Strategic risks.

Business objective progress.

Executive engagement.

Relationship strength.

Commercial readiness.

Expansion opportunities.

Quarterly reviews help ensure that long-term business priorities remain aligned.

Renewal Reviews

Risk reviews become increasingly important as renewal approaches.

Beginning 120 days before renewal, Customer Success Managers should review:

Commercial risks.

Executive sponsorship.

Procurement readiness.

Product adoption.

Business outcomes.

Stakeholder engagement.

Competitive threats.

Every unresolved risk should have a documented recovery plan before renewal discussions begin.

Event-Driven Reviews

Certain events require immediate risk reassessment regardless of the normal review schedule.

Examples include:

Executive leadership changes.

Company mergers.

Large workforce reductions.

Product outages.

Major support escalations.

Implementation delays.

Negative Executive Business Reviews.

Customer complaints.

Regulatory changes.

Waiting until the next scheduled review after one of these events can significantly increase customer risk.

Risk management should respond to customer reality---not simply to the calendar.

Chapter 12

Real World Case Study

LendWise

LendWise had experienced consistent customer growth, but leadership noticed an increasing number of renewals becoming unpredictable despite healthy implementation projects.

Customer Success Managers were documenting risks individually using spreadsheets, meeting notes, and CRM comments.

There was no standardized method for assessing probability, assigning ownership, or tracking mitigation activities.

As a result, several risks remained unnoticed until renewal conversations had already begun.

To solve this challenge, LendWise implemented a centralized Customer Risk Register across the entire Customer Success organization.

Every active customer risk was categorized according to:

Technical.

Operational.

Relationship.

Commercial.

Strategic.

Support.

Adoption.

Organizational.

Each risk included:

Probability.

Business impact.

Assigned owner.

Target resolution date.

Mitigation plan.

Current status.

Monthly Risk Review meetings were introduced alongside Customer Health Reviews.

High-risk accounts were reviewed weekly by Customer Success leadership.

One enterprise customer demonstrated healthy adoption but experienced a sudden leadership restructuring.

The executive sponsor who had championed the original purchase left the organization.

A new executive questioned whether the platform aligned with updated business priorities.

Although no customer complaint had been raised, the Risk Register immediately identified:

Relationship Risk --- High.

Commercial Risk --- Medium.

Renewal Risk --- High.

Rather than waiting for renewal discussions, the Customer Success Manager initiated executive alignment meetings, updated the Success Plan, rebuilt stakeholder relationships, and demonstrated measurable business outcomes achieved since implementation.

Within six weeks, executive confidence returned and renewal planning proceeded without delay.

The Risk Register transformed Customer Success from reacting to customer problems into proactively preventing them.

The greatest value wasn't documenting the risk.

It was acting before the customer experienced the consequences.

Chapter 13

Fully Completed Customer Risk Register

Customer Information

Customer: LendWise

Industry: Financial Technology

Customer Success Manager: David Maika

Review Date: July 2026

Risk	Category	Risk	Probability	Impact	Owner	Mitigation	Target	Status	ID	Description	Plan	Date
R-001	Relationship	Executive resigned alignment meetings and update stakeholder map	High	High	CSM	Schedule	July 25	In Progress	sponsor	executive		
R-002	Adoption	Advanced adoption below training and target monitor weekly adoption	Medium	Medium	CSM	Deliver	July 30	Open	workflow	additional		
R-003	Support	Increase in support tickets investigation	Medium	High	Support	Prioritize	August 5	In Progress	integration	Manager		

and weekly
updates

R-004 Commercial Procurement Medium Medium Sales Engage August 15 Open process delayed
Manager procurement
team early and
prepare renewal
documentation

R-005 Strategic Customer Low High Executive Conduct August 20 Monitoring restructuring Sponsor
Executive
may affect Business Review
priorities and validate
updated
business
objectives

Portfolio Summary

Total Active Risks: 5

High Risks: 2

Medium Risks: 2

Low Risks: 1

Critical Risks: 0

Immediate Actions

- Complete executive stakeholder alignment.
- Increase adoption coaching sessions.
- Monitor integration improvements weekly.
- Begin early renewal planning.
- Review all risks during next monthly Health Review.

This standardized Risk Register provides leadership with a single source of truth for monitoring, prioritizing, and resolving customer risks before they impact customer success.

Chapter 14

Common Mistakes

One of the biggest mistakes Customer Success teams make is documenting risks only after customers begin escalating issues.

At that point, Customer Success is responding to consequences rather than preventing them.

Another common mistake is treating every risk equally.

Not every issue deserves executive attention.

Organizations should prioritize risks according to probability and business impact, ensuring resources are focused where they create the greatest value.

Many teams also fail to assign clear ownership.

Risks shared across multiple departments often remain unresolved because everyone assumes someone else is responsible.

Accountability should always belong to one primary owner.

Another frequent mistake is failing to update mitigation plans.

A mitigation strategy created three months ago may no longer reflect the customer's current situation.

Risk Registers should evolve continuously alongside the customer relationship.

Some organizations also focus exclusively on technical risks while overlooking organizational, commercial, and relationship risks.

In reality, many renewals fail because of changing business priorities or stakeholder turnover rather than product issues.

Finally, Risk Registers are often treated as reporting documents instead of operational tools.

Their purpose is not to record customer problems.

Their purpose is to drive timely action that prevents those problems from affecting customer success.

Chapter 15

AI Workflow for Risk Management

Artificial Intelligence has fundamentally changed how Customer Success teams identify, assess, and manage customer risk.

Instead of manually reviewing CRM records, support tickets, meeting notes, emails, and product usage reports individually, AI can continuously analyze thousands of customer signals and identify patterns that humans might overlook.

This allows Customer Success Managers to spend less time gathering information and more time solving customer problems.

AI should be integrated into every stage of the Risk Management process.

Risk Identification

AI can monitor multiple customer data sources simultaneously, including:

CRM activity.

Product usage analytics.

Support tickets.

Implementation updates.

Meeting transcripts.

Email conversations.

Executive Business Reviews.

Survey responses.

Health Score trends.

Using these sources, AI can identify early warning signals such as:

Declining product adoption.

Reduced executive engagement.

Increasing support requests.

Missed implementation milestones.

Delayed customer responses.

Negative meeting sentiment.

Changes in customer priorities.

Rather than waiting for customers to report problems, AI highlights potential risks as they begin to emerge.

Risk Assessment

Once risks have been identified, AI can assist Customer Success Managers by estimating:

Probability.

Business impact.

Potential renewal risk.

Urgency.

Recommended escalation level.

For example, AI may recognize that several customers who previously exhibited similar behaviors eventually experienced unsuccessful renewals.

Although AI cannot predict the future with certainty, it can identify historical patterns that improve decision-making.

Risk Prioritization

Large Customer Success teams often manage hundreds of accounts simultaneously.

Without prioritization, important risks can easily be overlooked.

AI can automatically rank customer risks according to:

Customer value.

Renewal proximity.

Health Score trends.

Business impact.

Executive engagement.

Commercial importance.

This enables Customer Success Managers to focus their attention where it creates the greatest customer impact.

Risk Mitigation

AI can also generate first-draft recovery plans based on similar historical situations.

Examples include:

Scheduling executive alignment meetings.

Updating Success Plans.

Increasing Health Review frequency.

Delivering additional customer training.

Recommending stakeholder mapping updates.

Escalating product issues.

Preparing Executive Business Reviews.

The Customer Success Manager should always review and personalize these recommendations before sharing them with customers.

Executive Reporting

Preparing leadership updates often requires significant administrative work.

AI can automatically summarize:

Portfolio risks.

High-priority accounts.

Emerging customer trends.

Mitigation progress.

Executive escalations.

Renewal outlook.

This allows Customer Success leaders to make faster, data-informed decisions while maintaining visibility across the customer portfolio.

Practical Scenario

A Customer Success Manager oversees sixty enterprise accounts.

AI detects that three customers have experienced declining executive engagement, decreasing workflow completion, and increasing support escalations during the previous month.

Individually, none of these signals appear critical.

Together, they indicate growing renewal risk.

AI recommends:

Executive Business Reviews.

Stakeholder Mapping updates.

Customer Health Reviews.

Renewal Readiness Assessments.

After reviewing the recommendations, the Customer Success Manager confirms the findings, adjusts the recovery plans, and schedules meetings with each customer.

Several months later, all three accounts renew successfully.

AI did not prevent the risk.

It simply helped identify it early enough for Customer Success to intervene.

AI accelerates awareness.

Customer Success Managers create outcomes.

Chapter 16

Best Practices

Document risks as soon as they are identified rather than waiting for visible customer dissatisfaction.

Classify every risk using standardized categories so reporting remains consistent across the Customer Success organization.

Evaluate both probability and business impact before determining the urgency of a response.

Assign one accountable owner to every risk.

Shared responsibility should never replace individual accountability.

Review active risks regularly using a structured cadence that includes weekly, monthly, quarterly, and event-driven reviews.

Update mitigation plans whenever customer circumstances change.

Integrate Risk Reviews with Customer Health Reviews, Executive Business Reviews, and Renewal Readiness assessments to ensure risks remain visible throughout the customer lifecycle.

Escalate significant risks early rather than waiting until customer trust begins to decline.

Use AI to improve risk visibility, but rely on Customer Success Managers to apply business judgment and relationship context.

Finally, remember that the objective of Risk Management is not to eliminate uncertainty.

It is to ensure uncertainty never catches your team by surprise.

Chapter 17

Final Template

Customer Information

Customer Name:

Industry:

Customer Success Manager:

Review Date:

Renewal Date:

Active Risk Register

Risk Category	Risk	Probability	Impact	Owner	Mitigation	Target	Status	ID	Description	Plan	Date

Portfolio Summary

Total Active Risks:

High Risks:

Medium Risks:

Low Risks:

Critical Risks:

Immediate Actions

-
-
-

Escalations Required

-
-

.

Executive Notes

Next Review Date

Conclusion

Risk is an unavoidable part of every customer relationship.

Leadership changes, shifting priorities, implementation delays, declining adoption, commercial uncertainty, and organizational change are all natural realities that Customer Success teams will encounter.

What separates high-performing Customer Success organizations from the rest is not the absence of risk.

It is their ability to recognize risk early, respond consistently, and prevent small issues from becoming major customer problems.

A well-designed Risk Register provides the structure needed to achieve exactly that.

It creates visibility, accountability, consistency, and proactive decision-making across the entire customer lifecycle.

When combined with Customer Health Scores, Executive Business Reviews, Success Plans, and Stakeholder Mapping, the Risk Register becomes one of the most powerful operational tools in Customer Success.

The goal is never to create a document full of risks.

The goal is to create a customer experience where most risks are resolved long before the customer ever realizes they existed.

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About the Author

David Maika is a Customer Success professional with experience spanning customer operations, process improvement, CRM implementation, project management, and business strategy. His work focuses on helping organizations improve customer outcomes, strengthen operational efficiency, and build scalable systems that support long-term growth.

Through practical frameworks, real-world case studies, and modern AI-assisted workflows, he aims to make Customer Success knowledge accessible, actionable, and valuable for professionals at every stage of their careers.

To learn more, access additional resources, or connect professionally, visit davidmaika.com or linkedin.com/in/davidmaika.

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